hiding their territorial ambitions, which had so far been restricted to the Garhwal and Kumaon regions in the Central Sector.

Finally, around the same time that the Chinese occupied the Khurnak Fort, two Indian patrols left Leh to physically verify the presence of the highway. The patrol sent to confirm the southern part of the road sent in its verification by October, but the second patrol commanded by an Engineer officer that had gone to the northern side disappeared. On 18 October, the Indians finally confronted the Chinese:

> The attention of the Government of India has recently been drawn to the fact that a motor road has been constructed by the Government of the People's Republic of China across the eastern part of the Ladakh region of the Jammu and Kashmir State, which is part of India. This road seems to form part of the Chinese road known as Yehcheng-Gartok road or Sinkiang-Tibet highway, the completion of which was announced in September 1957. The road enters Indian territory just east of Sarigh Jilgnang, runs north-west to Amtogar and striking the western bank of the Amtogar lake runs north-west through Yangpa, Khitai Dawan and Haji Langar which are all in indisputable Indian territory. Near the Amtogar lake several branch tracks have also been made motorable.

The note went on to protest that the highway was encroaching into Indian territory, into regions that were well established as Indian for centuries and accepted by the Chinese as Indian territory. It also brought up the issue of the missing patrol and asked China for information on the party and 'any assistance that they may find it possible to give' to ensure that the patrol was able to return. On 22 October 1958, the three officers and eight civilians were 'deported' after being given a severe warning. In its reply to the Indian protest note, the Chinese government predictably charged that it was the Indian armed personnel who had intruded into their territory.

At the same time, India had sent a note to the Chinese government about their maps that showed the India-Tibet border in the east as running along the foothills of NEFA and ignored the McMahon Line altogether. In the west, the Aksai Chin was shown as part of Chinese territory. The Chinese reply to this note was cryptic and claimed that the maps were pre-liberation ones and that a survey had not been undertaken. They assured the Indian government that new boundaries would be marked in consultation with the countries concerned. The Chinese stand only confirmed what Patel had foreseen eight years earlier—the People's Republic of China had thrown out all the past frontier settlements that the Indian government had concluded with Tibet.